

Syllabus

Language Arts Level 4

In the Level 4 course, students exercise their critical thinking skills in the study of language across American history. Each quarter, students engage with high-level texts to increase comprehension, and address authentic scenarios that cultivate problem-solving skills and hone each student's development of purposeful, quality writing.

The goal of AoPS Academy Language Arts courses is to train the intellectual leaders of the next generation by fostering creative problem solving. In our classes, students tackle projects that are framed as interpretation and communication problems: how can we communicate an idea in just the right way? Or, how can we understand complex ideas that are being communicated to us? To solve these problems, students must craft written pieces and oral presentations that demonstrate mastery of the Language Arts skills they learned in class. In this way, our courses help students develop the confidence and advanced literacy skills they need to solve any communication problem they encounter, whether it's in college, in the professional world, or in their own lives.

Time Commitment: This 36-week course includes 105 minutes of in-class instruction and 60-90 minutes of homework each week, corresponding to a full-year course.

Homework: Students should expect to spend about 1–2 hours on homework every week. Homework will include practicing the reading, writing, and grammar skills covered in class, working on ongoing writing projects, and completing reading assignments. Students are expected to read independently throughout the year from assigned novels and nonfiction books. Students will take weekly reading quizzes on the course homepage to ensure that they are keeping up with the reading.

Content:

Week	Topic	Week	Topic
1	Course and Unit 1 Introduction	19	Unit 3 Introduction
2	Craft Your Setting and Narrator	20	Forming Your Opinion
3	Conflict in a Story	21	Building the Arguments
4	Character Impact	22	Attention and Direction
5	Sending the Message with Plot	23	Closing with a Call to Action
6	Metaphor and Appositive	24	Punctuating Direct Quotes
7	Strengthening Message with Similes	25	Using Modal Auxiliary Verbs
8	Draft Review and Revisions	26	Asking the Audience: Peer Reviews
9	Sharing Revolutionary Works!	27	Proposal Presentation Day!
10	Unit 2 Introduction	28	Unit 4 Introduction
11	Research and Thesis, Part 1	29	A Poet's Supersenses
12	Research and Supports, Part 2	30	Keeping Tense and POV
13	Hooking Viewers with Introductions	31	Heavy Lifters and Precise Descriptors
14	Click-worthy Conclusions	32	This is My EnJAMbment
15	Relative Adverbs	33	Prepositional Phrases
16	Correcting Run-Ons	34	Punctuation for Power
17	Peer Reviews	35	Workshopping Words and Performance Prep
18	Presentations from the Scene	36	Performance Poetry Slam: Capsule Closure

The course is divided into four project-based units:

Unit	Description	Common Core Standards	Core Skills or Concepts
1 Building Narratives	Students explore influential texts of the Revolutionary period. Students use their study of competing narratives to write a one-act, humorous Revolutionary play that communicates a Loyalist or Patriot point of view. Book: <i>King George: What Was His Problem?</i>	RL 4.1-4.6, 4.10 RI 4.1-4.3 W 4.3A-E, 4.4-4.5, 4.9A-B, 4.10 SL 4.1ACD, 4.2, 4.4 L 4.3A-B, 4.4A-B, 4.5AC, 4.6	Analysis of informational narratives; brainstorming and drafting outlines; building lifelike characters; incorporating first and third P.O.V.; exploring character-driven conflict; publishing and performing an original narrative for a target audience
2 Expository Essays	Students are introduced to both voices from the Civil War era, as they use careful analysis to develop evidence-based expository essays. Students' essays serve as the foundation for a live "documentary" presentation in class Book: <i>Last of the Name</i>	RL 4.1, 4.2, 4.3, 4.10 RI 4.1-4.4, 4.6, 4.8-10 RF 3.4A, 3.4B W 4.2 A-E, 4.4-5, 4.7-4.10 A-B SL 4.1ACD, 4.2-4.4 L 4.1 BG, 4.3 A-B, 4.4 A-B, 4.5 AC, 4.6	Literary analysis of historical fiction; crafting introductions and thesis statements; using research to support claims; incorporating purposeful transitions; building a summative conclusion; creating an original expository essay for a target audience
3 Persuasive Essays	Students learn to evaluate the author's point of view, methods of persuasion, and explore how popular opinions are often formed. Students end the unit by developing a persuasive proposal to nominate a chosen historical figure to be memorialized in a town square. Book: <i>The Woman's Hour</i>	RL 4.1, 4.2, 4.3, 4.10 RI 4.1-4.4, 4.6, 4.8-10 W 4.1 A-D, 4.4-5, 4.7-4.10 SL 4.1 ACD, 4.2, 4.3, 4.4 L 4.1D, 4.2 B, 4.4 A-B, 4.5 AC, 4.6	Analysis of narrative nonfiction; using research to craft an informed opinion; guiding project design, creating a persuasive approach; creating a powerful closing; self-reflective and collaborative revision; presentation of a convincing persuasive proposal
4 Poetry Composition	This unit culminates in the study of masterful poetry. As students read and analyze a work of poetic memoir, students craft their own personal narratives in poetic form, thereby contributing to a collective "history" of their class's lifetimes. Book: <i>Brown Girl Dreaming</i>	RL 4.1, 4.2, 4.3, 4.5, 4.6, 4.10 W 4.3 A-E, 4.4, 4.5, 4.9 A, 4.10 SL 4.1 A-D, 4.2, 4.4 L 4.1 F, 4.3 A-B, 4.4 A-C, 4.5 AC, 4.6	Literary analysis of a memoir in poetry; relaying formative moments in free verse poetic form; using descriptive imagery; writing first person narration; evaluating word choice; utilizing structural manipulation and intentional punctuation; performing poetry

To interpret the Common Core Standards column on the table above, visit the Common Core ELA website at www.corestandards.org/ELA-Literacy.